

YOUTH CAPACITY BUILDING NETWORK (YCBN)

A REPORT ON THE CONTINENTAL ONLINE DIALOGUE

Theme: “How Small NGOs Can Compete for Large Funding Opportunities”

Date: Sunday, 9th August 2026

Time: 9:00 PM – 10:00 PM (EAT)

Platform: Google Meet

Organizer: Youth Capacity Building Network (YCBN)

Host & Moderator: Mr. Simon Peter Kigozi, Public Relations Officer – YCBN

Guest Speaker: Ms. Margaret Gitau, Founder and Lead Consultant, NobleCause Consultancy Firm, Nairobi, Kenya



YOUTH CAPACITY BUILDING NETWORK
sustainable WASH for all.

Presents



GOOGLE MEET

YCBN REGIONAL DIALOGUE

How Small NGOs Can Compete for Large Funding Opportunities

Insights. Strategies. Opportunities.
Position Your NGO. Win Bigger.



HOST

SIMON PETER KIGOZI

Public Relations Officer
Youth Capacity Building Network

📍 **UGANDA**



GUEST SPEAKER

MARGARET GITAU

Resource Mobilization Strategist
for Nonprofits

📍 **KENYA – NAIROBI**



DATE

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Introduction

The Youth Capacity Building Network (YCBN) successfully convened a continental online dialogue on Sunday, 9th August 2026, under the theme “**How Small NGOs Can Compete for Large Funding Opportunities.**”

The dialogue was organized as part of YCBN’s commitment to strengthening the capacity of youth leaders, civil society organizations, NGOs, WASH practitioners, development actors, researchers, and other stakeholders across Africa.

The session brought together participants from different African countries, including **Uganda, Kenya, Zimbabwe, and Nigeria**, creating an opportunity for cross-country learning, knowledge exchange, and discussion on practical approaches that small and emerging NGOs can adopt to become more competitive for large-scale funding opportunities.

The dialogue was hosted and moderated by **Mr. Simon Peter Kigozi, Public Relations Officer of YCBN**, while the keynote presentation was delivered by **Ms. Margaret Gitau from Nairobi, Kenya**, Founder and Lead Consultant at Noble Cause Consultancy Firm.



Objectives of the Dialogue

The dialogue aimed to:

Equip small and emerging NGOs with practical knowledge on how to position themselves for larger funding opportunities.

Help NGOs understand the factors that influence funders' confidence and funding decisions.

Highlight the importance of strong governance, financial systems, impact evidence, digital credibility, and funding diversification.

Strengthen participants' understanding of how to develop competitive and funder-aligned proposals.

Promote strategic partnerships and consortium approaches as avenues for accessing larger funding opportunities.

Encourage NGOs to shift from reactive fundraising to strategic institutional positioning.

Provide participants with a practical 90-day action plan for improving their funding readiness.

Programme and Proceedings

The dialogue followed the official programme developed by YCBN. The session commenced at **9:00 PM EAT** with an opening prayer, followed by welcome remarks, the official opening, and an introduction to YCBN and the dialogue theme.

Mr. Simon Peter Kigozi, who served as host and moderator, subsequently introduced the guest speaker and facilitated participant introductions. Ms. Margaret Gitau then delivered the keynote presentation, followed by an interactive question-and-answer session.

The dialogue concluded with closing remarks, appreciation, and the official closure by **Mr. Frank Mwanje, Executive Director of YCBN.**

Keynote Presentation



Ms. Margaret Gitau's presentation provided participants with practical insights into why some small NGOs struggle to secure large grants and what they can do to become more competitive.

Her presentation covered seven major areas:

1. Why small NGOs lose large grants
2. What large funders are looking for
3. The five pillars of competitive positioning
4. Building a funding-readiness foundation
5. Crafting competitive proposals
6. Strategic partnerships as a funding lever
7. Developing a 90-day action plan

Why Small NGOs Lose Large Grants

A major message from the presentation was that small NGOs do not necessarily lose funding because their missions or programs are weak. Rather, they may lose opportunities because their organizational structures and systems do not inspire sufficient confidence among funders.

Ms. Gitau identified several issues that can negatively affect an NGO's competitiveness, including:

Governance gaps and weak board structures;

1. Lack of independently reviewed financial records;
2. Weak impact evidence and overreliance on activity reports;
3. Poor or inactive digital presence; and
4. Excessive dependence on a single source of funding.

Participants were therefore encouraged to understand that **institutional credibility is as important as programme quality** when competing for significant funding opportunities.

What Large Funders Evaluate

The presentation highlighted the importance of donor due diligence. Before considering the quality of a proposal, funders are likely to assess whether an organization can responsibly manage funds, meet legal and governance requirements, demonstrate credible impact, remain financially stable, and sustain its work over time.

The presentation also emphasized the importance of an NGO's digital presence in building trust and demonstrating professionalism.

This was an important lesson for participating organizations: **a strong proposal alone may not be sufficient if the organization lacks the institutional systems required to implement and account for a major grant.**

The Five Pillars of Competitive Positioning

Ms. Gitau presented five key pillars that small NGOs should strengthen in order to compete effectively for large funding opportunities:

Governance

Organizations should have functioning boards, documented policies, clear roles, and accountability structures.

Financial Systems

NGOs should maintain transparent financial records, appropriate financial controls, audited accounts where applicable, and independent financial oversight.

Impact Evidence

Organizations need to demonstrate results rather than simply reporting activities. This requires outcome data, monitoring and evaluation frameworks, and credible evidence of beneficiary results.

Digital Credibility

A professional website, active social media presence, and good online visibility can contribute significantly to an organization's credibility.

Funding Diversification

NGOs were encouraged to develop multiple income streams, including grants, donors, corporate social responsibility opportunities, and earned income, rather than relying heavily on one funder.

Building a Funding-Ready Organization

A significant component of the presentation was the proposed **90-day funding readiness plan**.

The immediate priorities included formal registration, establishing a dedicated organizational bank account, conducting board meetings and keeping proper minutes, and improving the organization's website.

Within the first 30 days, NGOs were encouraged to develop safeguarding policies, establish financial tracking systems, and document at least one completed programme with measurable outcomes.

Within 60 days, organizations were encouraged to develop a theory of change, establish monitoring and evaluation systems, and identify additional funding sources.

By 90 days, organizations were encouraged to undertake an independent financial review, explore appropriate digital fundraising opportunities, and establish a 12-month resource mobilization calendar.

This framework gave participants a practical pathway for moving from general interest in fundraising to actual institutional preparedness.

Developing Competitive Funding Proposals

Ms. Gitau introduced participants to the **Pain-Gap-Stakes framework** for developing strong problem statements.

Pain

NGOs should clearly describe the problem using specific and credible local data, identifying the affected population, scale, and severity.

Gap

Organizations should demonstrate what is missing from existing interventions and explain why the problem continues to affect the targeted population.

Stakes

Proposals should explain the consequences of inaction and clearly demonstrate who bears the greatest long-term cost if the problem remains unresolved.

The framework should then be supported by **SMART objectives, outcome data, a clear line-item budget, and language aligned with the priorities of the funder.**

Strategic Partnerships as a Funding Opportunity

Another major lesson from the dialogue was the importance of partnerships.

Ms. Gitau emphasized that strategic partnerships can enable smaller organizations to access funding, credibility, expertise, and reach that may take years to develop independently.

Potential partners highlighted included:

1. Larger NGOs through consortium arrangements;

2. Corporates seeking community partners through CSR programmes;
3. Government agencies through sub-granting arrangements; and

Peer organizations through resource sharing, joint proposals, shared monitoring and evaluation systems, and co-applications.

A particularly important message was that NGOs should approach potential partners with a **clear value proposition rather than simply presenting a funding need**. Small organizations should be able to demonstrate what they bring to a partnership.

Strategic Mindset Shift

The dialogue encouraged participants to reconsider the way they approach fundraising.

The presentation contrasted:

1. **Reactive fundraising** with **strategic funding positioning**;
2. **Short-term grants** with **sustainable funding ecosystems**;
3. **Proposal chasing** with **institutional credibility building**;
4. **Single-funder dependency** with **diversified income**; and **operations** with **donor-ready organizational infrastructure**.

This mindset shift was one of the central messages of the dialogue. Participants were encouraged to recognize that successful fundraising begins long before a funding call is announced.

The 90-Day Action Plan

To translate the lessons into action, Ms. Gitau presented a practical 90-day plan.

Weeks 1–2

Organizations should conduct a funding-readiness self-assessment, identify their three most significant gaps, and establish priorities.

Weeks 3–4

Organizations should strengthen their legal registration and governance documentation and improve their websites.

Month 2

Organizations should develop a theory of change, begin systematic monitoring and evaluation data collection, and identify qualified funding prospects.

Month 3

Organizations should submit a strategically aligned grant application, explore relevant digital opportunities, and establish a 12-month funding pipeline.

Participant Engagement and Learning

The dialogue provided participants with an interactive platform to learn from an experienced practitioner and to reflect on their own organizations' readiness for larger funding opportunities.

The participation of individuals from **Uganda, Kenya, Zimbabwe, Nigeria, and other African contexts** enriched the continental nature of the engagement. The diversity of participants demonstrated the relevance of the topic to NGOs and civil society actors operating in different national contexts.

The interactive question-and-answer session, moderated by Mr. Simon Peter Kigozi, enabled participants to engage with the issues raised during the keynote presentation and seek further clarification.

The official agenda identified the expected audience as including youth leaders, university students, government officials, WASH practitioners, CSO representatives, development partners, researchers, and academicians.

Key Lessons and Takeaways

The dialogue generated several important lessons for small and emerging NGOs:

Mission alone is not enough: Strong programmes must be supported by credible organizational systems.

Institutional credibility matters: Governance, financial accountability, impact evidence, and professionalism influence funder confidence.

Impact must be demonstrated: NGOs should move beyond reporting activities to demonstrating measurable outcomes.

Digital presence matters: A professional and active online presence can contribute to organizational credibility.

Funding should be diversified: Organizations should avoid excessive dependence on one funder.

Proposal quality matters: Strong proposals should clearly articulate the problem, the gap, the consequences of inaction, measurable objectives, expected outcomes, and realistic budgets.

Partnerships can unlock opportunities: Smaller NGOs can access larger opportunities by forming strategic and mutually beneficial partnerships.

Fundraising requires preparation: Organizations should build funding readiness before funding calls are announced.

Small NGOs can compete: Size should not be viewed as an automatic barrier to accessing significant funding opportunities.

Strategic positioning is essential: Organizations should focus on becoming funder-ready rather than simply chasing funding opportunities.

Recommendations

Based on the discussions and presentation, participating NGOs and YCBN members are encouraged to:

1. Strengthen organizational governance and accountability systems.
2. Maintain accurate and transparent financial records.
3. Develop appropriate organizational policies and procedures.
4. Establish functional monitoring and evaluation systems.
5. Document and communicate measurable programme outcomes.

6. Improve organizational websites and digital visibility.
7. Develop theories of change for key programmes.
8. Diversify funding sources and develop resource mobilization strategies.
9. Build relationships with larger NGOs, government institutions, corporations, development partners, and peer organizations.
10. Develop a pipeline of potential funding opportunities rather than relying on ad hoc applications.
11. Conduct regular funding-readiness assessments.
12. Implement the 90-day action plan presented during the dialogue.

Conclusion

The YCBN Continental Online Dialogue on “**How Small NGOs Can Compete for Large Funding Opportunities**” provided a valuable learning and networking platform for participants across Africa.

The keynote presentation by Ms. Margaret Gitau demonstrated that small NGOs can significantly improve their competitiveness by strengthening their governance, financial systems, impact evidence, digital credibility, and funding diversification. It further emphasized the importance of strategic partnerships, high-quality proposals, and long-term institutional positioning.

The dialogue also reinforced YCBN’s role in creating platforms through which African youth leaders, NGOs, civil society actors, practitioners, researchers, and other stakeholders can access knowledge, share experiences, and strengthen their organizational capacity.

The overall message of the engagement was clear: **small organizations should not simply chase funding opportunities; they should deliberately build the systems, credibility, evidence, partnerships, and strategic positioning that make them ready to compete for them.**

As highlighted in the presentation, “**Strong organizations do not chase funding. They position themselves for it.**”